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Section Title(S)

AVOIDANCE OF NAMES • FORMS OF RESPECTFUL ADDRESS

The forms of address that are used when a person's name is avoided are discussed below. With one exception (in the use of pronouns), these forms are applicable both when one is according reserved behavior to a person and when one is simply showing respect.

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FORMS OF RESPECTFUL ADDRESS

A common way to avoid using someone's name is to use a kin term instead. Kin terms are always permissible and respectful. It is my impression that kin terms are used not only as part of reserved behavior or to show respect for one's elders, but as ordinary forms of address between persons who have the joking relationship and are of the same age.

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People also frequently use descriptive phrases, such as "mother of my wife," "father of my daughter's husband," and so forth.

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The language of the !Kung includes both familiar and respectful second-person-singular pronouns. The familiar pronoun, *a*, is used in addressing any child, and is used between persons who have the joking relationship, regardless of disparities in age. It is also used between brother and sister until they grow up, when they change to the respectful pronoun. The respectful pronoun, *i*, is used only between persons who accord each other reserved behavior. It is not used to show respect for one's elders, whom it is

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perfectly appropriate to address using the familiar pronoun, provided one may joke with them.

The respectful second-person-singular pronoun, *i*, is also the pronoun used for the second-person plural, both respectful and familiar.

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The !Kung use several terms in respectful address. One term is *mama*. It is applied, man-speaking and woman-speaking, to any adult and is commonly used. It implies respect, but respect mingled with warmth and intimacy, not the respect that requires reserved behavior and keeping one's distance. It is so often used for grandparents that I thought at first it was the kin term for grandparent. It is used when the speaker wishes to express affection, approval, gratitude. It is also used when one wishes to ingratiate himself mildly with the person he ad-have PAGE 247 IS BLANK PAGE 248 named the child for his father or mother, and therefore they use those names for N/ aoka.

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Naming

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